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THE TACTICAL NUKES THREAT

- Tactical Nuclear Weapons (TNW) are smaller nuclear weapons meant for battlefield use
- They have a smaller yield, starting from 1 kiloton, and a lesser range of around 100 km and above; delivered through artillery, short-range missiles and gravity bombs
- Once used, it will create a blast and fire, followed by a radioactive wasteland, killing over 20,000 in blast effects and thermal radiation within a 1–2 km radius
- Pakistan reportedly has over 20 tactical nukes, meant to counter India's conventional superiority
- India, which believes in an overwhelming nuclear counter-strike, has deliberately not developed TNWs

Gen. Munir, Shehbaz Sharif and India's national security advisor Ajit Doval. In a social media post, Rubio thanks these leaders and says that both countries had not only agreed to an immediate ceasefire but also "to start talks on a broad set of issues at a neutral site". This seemed in consonance with state department spokesperson Tammy Bruce's read-out of Rubio's conversations with Munir and Jaishankar. The one with Munir read, "He continued to urge both parties to find ways to de-escalate and offered US assistance in starting constructive talks in order to avoid future conflicts." The read-out with Jaishankar, on the other hand, went thus: "Rubio emphasised that both sides need to identify methods to de-escalate and re-establish communication to avoid miscalculation. He further proposed US support in facilitating productive discussions to avert future disputes." Posting his take on the conversation, Jaishankar's message on X read: "Had a conversation with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio this morning. India's approach has always been measured and responsible and remains so."

The Endgame

In off-the-record briefings, however, the MEA says there was no such agreement to resume talks with Pakistan as it would run contrary to India's stated policy of no talks unless Pakistan turns off the terror tap. Christopher Clary, assistant professor of Political Science at the University at Albany, State University of New York, and an expert on South Asian nuclear issues, believes the truce came about through a combination of factors, including the likelihood of US intelligence agencies observing a change in the readiness status of Pakistan's nuclear assets. "My hypothesis," says Clary, "is that a combination of Indian military pressure combined with US inducements created a mix of carrots and sticks that made Pakistan indicate it could cease hostilities." Curtis agrees that India and Pakistan would not have agreed to a ceasefire on their own and needed third-party intervention to step back from the nuclear brink.

Pakistan, though, saw Trump's observations and Rubio's comments as a significant victory. Not only did Trump, in a subsequent briefing, offer to mediate between India and Pakistan on Kashmir, the US also told India to hold talks on key issues. Pakistan claimed they were able to internationalise the Kashmir issue again and get re-hyphenated with India. Gen. Munir got himself promoted to Field Marshal to demonstrate his clout and cement his status as the de facto czar of Pakistan.

The sense of triumphalism in the Pakistan military worries Curtis. "It makes it seem like this act of terrorism helped draw international attention to Kashmir and sends a wrong signal that could encourage more violence in the future," she says. "It doesn't help calm tensions in the region." She believes the US must quietly work behind the scenes to encourage the two sides to get some kind of bilateral dialogue going, including on the issues of terrorism and nuclear risk reduction.

Most admit the truce is tenuous, and another terrorist act could trigger a resumption of hostilities. Husain Haqqani, a former Pakistan ambassador to the US and senior fellow, Hudson Institute, Washington DC, says, "The jihadis may want to break the peace, but I think Pakistan will now put a leash on them as they don't want to go down this path again." The real problem, Haqqani fears, is that the public in both countries is jingoistic and seemingly unaware of the grave dangers of a nuclear miscalculation. "Our attitude seems to be that even if the plane we are travelling in is crashing, we are laughing and asking for more whisky," he says. Hassan Khan believes India and Pakistan need to build an architecture that can sort out such things immediately before they get into "a commitment trap" that pushes them towards a dangerous war. Tellis thinks the longer term challenge is now tied up with the future of India-Pakistan relations and cannot be resolved without actual engagement between the two countries. "To my mind, the question is how do you punish the enemy by minimising the risks to yourself," he says. Talking about nuclear war, a sci-fi movie from the Cold War era had this line: "It is a strange game. The only winning move is not to play." It could be a tactic worth practising. ■